

Windows C Drive Cleanup Guide (Safe Methods)

Method 1: Built-in Disk Cleanup

Using Disk Cleanup Tool

```
cmd

# Run Disk Cleanup
cleanmgr /c

# Or for more options:
cleanmgr /sageset:1
cleanmgr /sagerun:1
```

Using Storage Sense (Windows 10/11)

- Go to Settings > System > Storage
- Click "Configure Storage Sense or run it now"
- Enable Storage Sense and configure cleanup options

Method 2: Temporary Files Cleanup

```
powershell

# Clean temporary files (run as Administrator)
# Windows Temp folder
Remove-Item -Path "$env:WINDIR\Temp\*" -Recurse -Force -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue

# User Temp folder
Remove-Item -Path "$env:TEMP\*" -Recurse -Force -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue

# Prefetch files
Remove-Item -Path "$env:WINDIR\Prefetch\*" -Force -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue

# Recent files
Remove-Item -Path "$env:APPDATA\Microsoft\Windows\Recent\*" -Force -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue
```

Method 3: System File Cleanup

cmd

Run as Administrator

Clean system files and component store

Dism.exe /online /Cleanup-Image /StartComponentCleanup /ResetBase

Clean Windows Update files

Dism.exe /online /Cleanup-Image /SPSuperseded

System File Checker

sfc /scannow

Method 4: Browser Cache Cleanup

powershell

Chrome Cache

Remove-Item -Path "\$env:LOCALAPPDATA\Google\Chrome\User Data\Default\Cache*" -Recurse -Force -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue

Firefox Cache

Remove-Item -Path "\$env:LOCALAPPDATA\Mozilla\Firefox\Profiles*\cache2*" -Recurse -Force -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue

Edge Cache

Remove-Item -Path "\$env:LOCALAPPDATA\Microsoft\Edge\User Data\Default\Cache*" -Recurse -Force -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue

Method 5: Windows Update Cleanup

cmd

Stop Windows Update service

net stop wuauerv

net stop cryptSvc

net stop bits

net stop msiserver

Clear update cache

rd /s /q %windir%\SoftwareDistribution

rd /s /q %windir%\System32\catroot2

Restart services

net start wuauerv

net start cryptSvc

net start bits

net start msiserver

Method 6: Large File Detection

powershell

Find large files (over 100MB)

```
Get-ChildItem -Path C:\ -Recurse -File -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue |  
Where-Object {$_.Length -gt 100MB} |  
Sort-Object Length -Descending |  
Select-Object Name, Directory, @{Name="Size(MB)";Expression={[math]::Round($_.Length/1MB,2)}} |  
Format-Table -AutoSize
```

Method 7: Application-Specific Cleanup

Visual Studio/Development Tools

cmd

Visual Studio temp files

```
rd /s /q "%LOCALAPPDATA%\Microsoft\VisualStudio\*\ComponentModelCache"  
rd /s /q "%LOCALAPPDATA%\Microsoft\VisualStudio\*\Extensions"
```

Docker (if installed)

cmd

```
docker system prune -a  
docker volume prune
```

Node.js (if used)

cmd

```
npm cache clean --force
```

Safe Folders to Clean Manually

- `%TEMP%` - Temporary files
- `%LOCALAPPDATA%\Temp` - Local app temp files
- `C:\Windows\Temp` - Windows temp files
- `%APPDATA%\Microsoft\Windows\Recent` - Recent files shortcuts
- Downloads folder (check before deleting)
- Recycle Bin
- Browser downloads folder

Folders/Files to NEVER Delete

- C:\Windows\System32
- C:\Program Files
- C:\Program Files (x86)
- C:\Users\[Username]\AppData\Roaming (be very careful)
- Registry files
- System drivers
- Boot files

Additional Tools (Third-party)

Safe and Popular Options:

- **CCleaner** (use with caution, uncheck registry cleaner)
- **BleachBit** (open source)
- **Wise Disk Cleaner**
- **TreeSize** (for finding large files/folders)

Safety Tips

1. Always create a system restore point before major cleanup
2. Close all applications before running cleanup commands
3. Run commands as Administrator when required
4. Never delete files you're unsure about
5. Keep important data backed up
6. Use Windows built-in tools first before third-party software